GEOGRAPHY IN HISTORY

3.4 An Ally in the American Victory

MAIN IDEA The physical and human characteristics, as well as the "site" and "situation," of locations have helped shape events in history.

In 1776, no one in the world believed the American colonists could defeat the mighty British Army. Yet throughout history, geography has affected how events have unfolded, and this was certainly the case during the American Revolution. The Continental Army had several types of geographic advantages: terrain, population distribution, distance, and climate. For example, the Continental Army spent the winter of 1777–78 at Valley Forge in Pennsylvania. The climate there was cold—and the cold shaped events. As you know, the soldiers suffered greatly from a lack of sufficient clothing and shelter. Yet the bad weather prevented the British from attacking them.



The Catskill Mountains in New York State are covered with thick forests that provided cover for the Continental Army and challenges for the British as they approached.

Study these examples of the geographic advantages that favored the Continental Army. Consider the information provided about each site—the physical characteristics of the example given. Then consider the situation or the location of each site in relation to other places.

European Claims in North America, 1776



TERRAIN

SITE The terrain of upstate New York is mountainous and heavily forested, with many rivers and streams.

SITUATION The Americans were familiar with the terrain, which gave them an enormous advantage. For example, in 1777, British troops marched from Canada toward New York to attack the Continental Army. Americans cut down trees and wrecked bridges, slowing down British troops. This gave the Americans time to gather more than 11,000 troops at Saratoga, where they defeated the British.

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The Original Thirteen Colonies, 1776

40,000 people
population of Philadelphia in 1776

POPULATION DISTRIBUTION

SITE The area of the colonies was large, but the population was relatively small—about 2.5 million people. Cities were also small, as most people lived on farms, so the population was widely scattered.

SITUATION The population was so widely distributed that the British couldn't simply attack one or two cities to defeat the Americans. In addition, the Continental Army could hide from British troops in unpopulated territory.

COLONIAL POPULATION, 1776



Source: *The Economist*

1,580 miles
from northern border of Maine
to southern border of Georgia

DISTANCE

SITE The colonies stretched more than 1,500 miles from north to south and more than 350 miles from east to west.

SITUATION The 13 colonies were located more than 3,000 miles from Great Britain. The distance created enormous problems for the British. They had to transport soldiers, supplies, and munitions by sailing ships. When the troops reached North America, they took weeks to march from one field of combat to another.

97 miles
from New York City
to Philadelphia

370 miles
from New York City
to Fort Pitt

3,460 miles
from London, England, to New York City

763 miles
from New York City
to Charleston

CLIMATE

SITE The British were not used to the cold winters of the northern states. The heat and humidity of the southern states were unfamiliar to the British, too.

SITUATION The Americans used their knowledge of the climate during the war. In the winter of 1775, Washington wanted artillery transported from New York to Boston. Colonel Henry Knox used 42 sleds pulled by oxen to transport the artillery over snow and ice. The Americans used the weapons to drive the British out of Boston.

THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

1. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** Why did distance pose problems for British troops during the American Revolution?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the Americans use geography to gain an advantage over the British?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Of the four geographic factors, which one do you think had the greatest impact on the war? Explain your reasons.

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